

Church Website Design

Jessica Miller

Project overview



The product:

I am revamping the websites for two parishes: The Church of the Most Precious Blood and Saint Theresa of Lisieux Parish. The Archdiocese of Boston has not provided branding guidelines during this second project of three planned over a decade. My goal is to include online donation features.



Project duration:

January 2011 to May 2011



Project overview



The problem:

The two parishes are working in partnership, but the current website does not effectively convey this collaboration. It is challenging to navigate and lacks visual appeal for visitors. Moreover, the site needs to meet the requirements established by the Archdiocese of Boston.



The goal:

The goal is to revamp the website to highlight the partnership between the two parishes, making it user-friendly and visually appealing. Built on Joomla as the CMS, it will allow easy updates and efficient management. The site will be fully responsive for all devices and feature intuitive navigation to enhance user experience, adhering to Archdiocese of Boston standards.

Project overview



My role:

As the UX designer at the helm of our website redesign, I'm excited to lead a transformative journey that enhances user experience and brings our digital presence to life!



Responsibilities:

Conducting interviews, paper and digital wireframing, low and high-fidelity prototyping, conducting usability studies, accounting for accessibility, iterating on designs and responsive design.

Understanding the user

- User research
- Personas
- Problem statements
- User journey maps

User research: summary



By conducting user interviews and creating empathy maps, I collected important insights into our target audience's needs, which helped shape the objectives for the website redesign. My findings indicated that while many users value the convenience and accessibility of online platforms, especially for activities like discovering and engaging with communities, website navigation that is confusing and overwhelming can quickly turn a positive experience into a frustrating one. This significantly affects their ability to locate information, interact with the site, and ultimately, connect with the church.

User research: pain points

1

Navigation

Navigation issues include confusing menus, poor search, broken links, and difficulty finding information.

2

Interaction

Interaction problems involve slow loading, cumbersome forms, lack of feedback, and buggy interfaces.

3

Experience

Experience pain points consist of cluttered design, unclear calls to action, poor content, and lack of trust signals.

Persona: **Eleanor Vance**

Problem statement:

Retired North Andover teacher (62) struggles with her parish's website: outdated info, poor design, and difficult donations hinder her connection with the church.



Quote:

"I just want to find what I need quickly."

Background: Widow, active in community.

Goal: Easily find parish info (services, contacts, events) and donate online.

Frustrations: Difficult navigation, outdated content, cluttered design, poor mobile experience.

User journey map

I created a user journey map of Eleanor's experience using the site to help identify possible pain points and improvement opportunities

Eleanor's Journey Map: Connecting with Her Parish Online

Action/Step	Task List	Feeling Adjective	Improvement Opportunity
1. Searching for the Parish Website	Opens Chromebook Types "St. Michael's Church North Andover" into Google Clicks on the first result	Hopeful, Determined	Ensure the church website is easily found in search results (SEO).
2. Navigating the Homepage	Scans the homepage for service times Looks for a "Contact Us" link Tries to find information about upcoming events	Frustrated, Confused	Simplify the homepage design. Clearly display key information like service times and contact details. Improve site navigation (clear menus, intuitive layout).
3. Finding Service Times	Clicks on a "Worship" link Scrolls through a long page of text Eventually finds the service times listed at the bottom	Annoyed, Relieved	Prominently display service times on the homepage or a dedicated "Visit Us" page. Use clear headings and formatting.
4. Trying to Donate Online	Clicks on a "Donate" button Is redirected to a third-party website Finds the donation process confusing and lengthy	Overwhelmed, Hesitant	Simplify the online donation process. Consider integrating donations directly into the website. Offer clear instructions and various payment options. Ensure the process feels secure and trustworthy.
5. Contacting the Church	Clicks on the "Contact Us" link Finds an email address but no phone number Writes an email with a question about an upcoming event	Slightly Frustrated, Resigned	Provide multiple contact options (phone number, email, contact form). Ensure contact information is up-to-date and easy to find.

Sitemap

Given Eleanor's difficulty with website navigation, I created a sitemap to address this primary pain point.

My goal was to make strategic information architecture decisions that would improve overall website navigation and create a simpler, more user-friendly experience.

Main Navigation

- Home

- About Us

 - Our History

 - Our Staff

 - Our Beliefs

- Visit Us

 - Service Times

 - Location & Directions

 - What to Expect

- Connect Events

 - Calendar

 - News & Updates

 - Contact Us

- Give

 - Online Donations

 - Other Ways to Give

- Footer

 - Privacy Policy

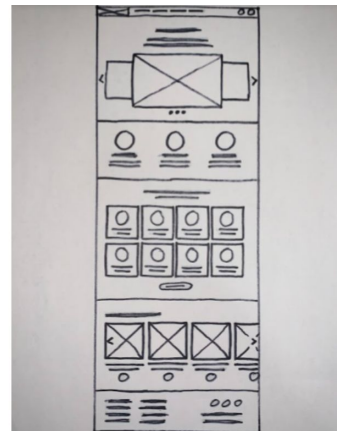
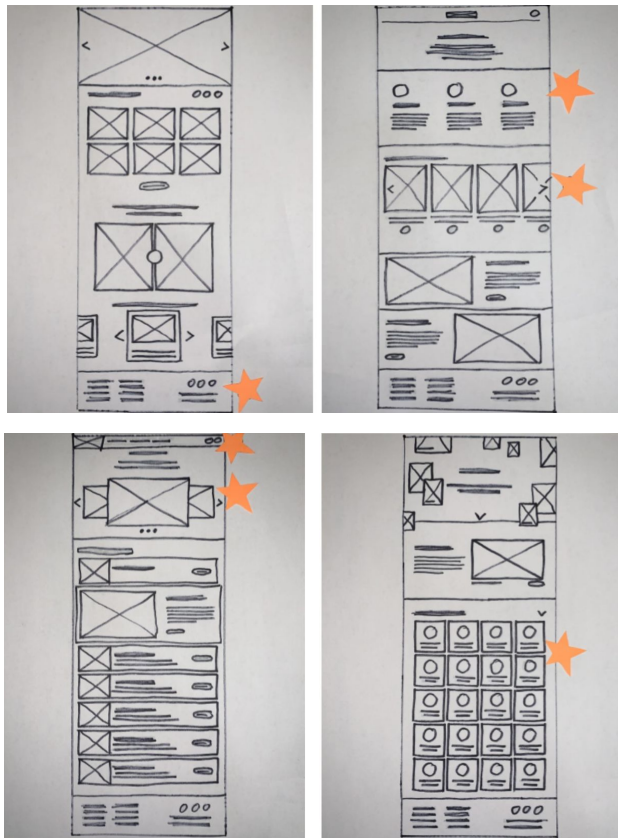
 - Terms of Service

 - Contact Information (address, phone number, email)

 - Social Media Links (if applicable)

Paper wireframes

To address Eleanor's frustrations, I sketched wireframes for each website screen, prioritizing navigation, information browsing, and donations. The home screen variations (right) optimize browsing for quick access to key information.

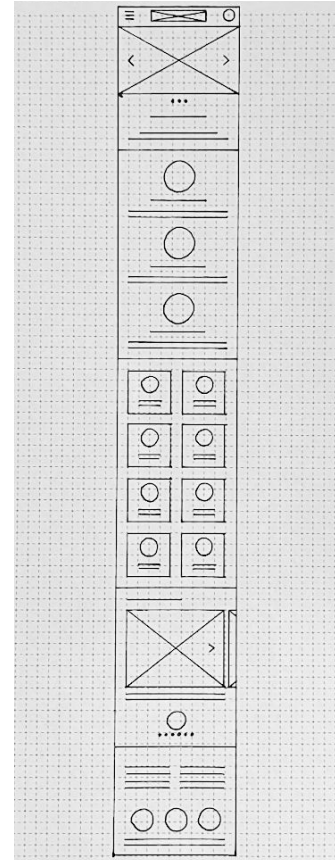
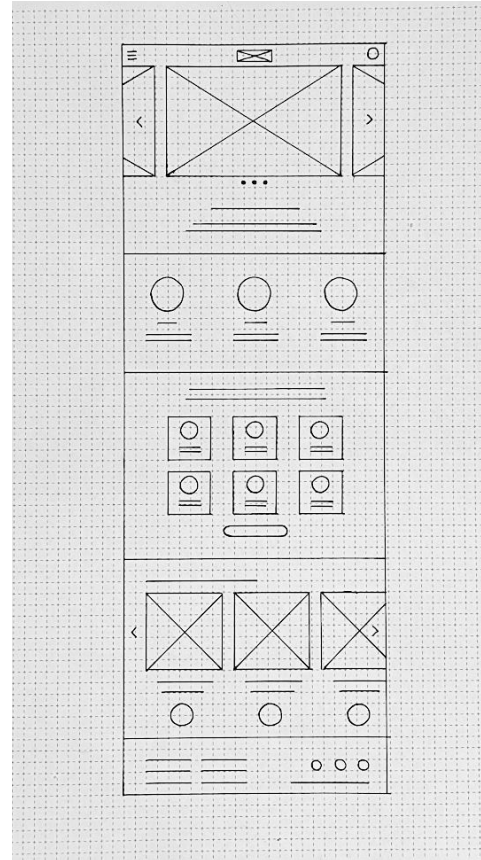


Refined paper wireframe

Stars were used to mark the elements of each sketch that would be used in the initial digital wireframes.

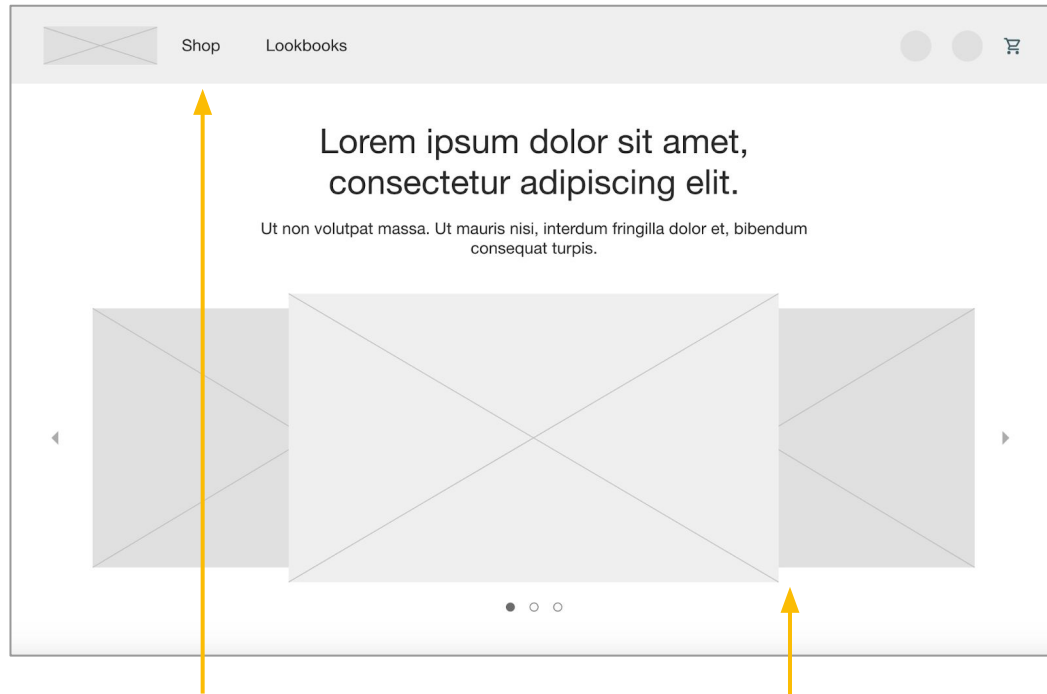
Paper wireframe screen size variations

To ensure the website is accessible on various devices, I began designing for different screen sizes, recognizing that users like Eleanor might access the site on anything from a Chromebook to a tablet or phone.



Digital wireframes

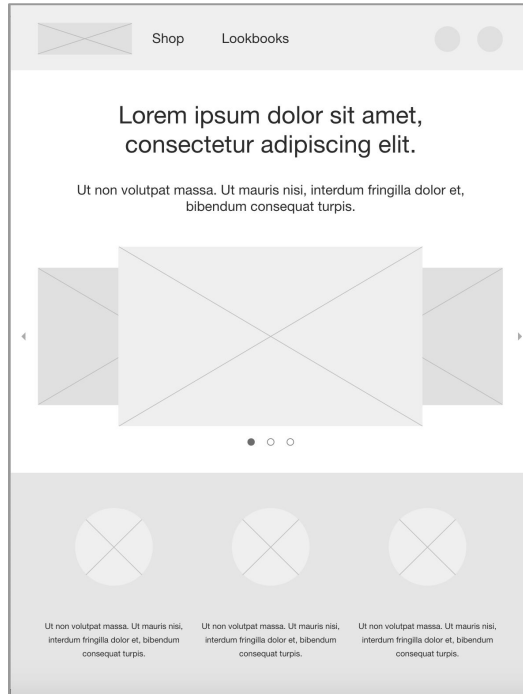
Transitioning to digital wireframes allowed me to visualize how the redesign would alleviate Eleanor's frustrations and improve her overall experience. A key focus was strategically placing buttons and visual elements on the homepage for maximum usability.



Easy access to shop products

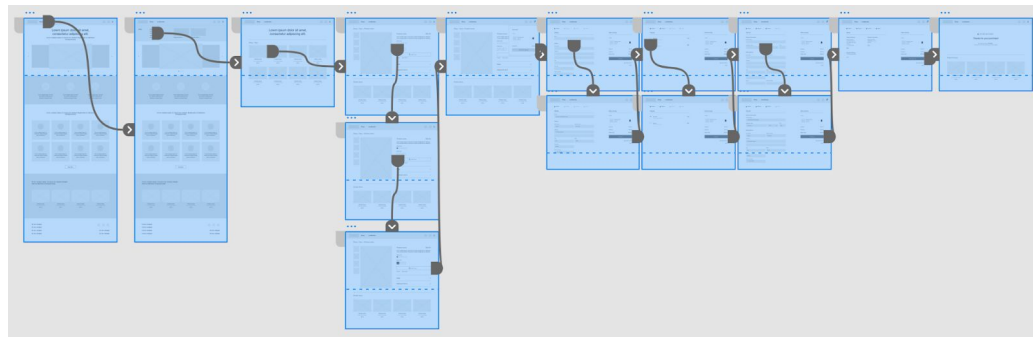
Homepage is optimized for easy browsing through the carousel of images and nav menu options

Digital wireframe screen size variation(s)



Low-fidelity prototype

To create a low-fidelity prototype, I linked all the screens involved in the primary user flow, from finding information about the church to online donations. I incorporated team feedback on design elements like button placement and page organization, focusing on suggestions that addressed Eleanor's pain points.



[View low-fidelity prototype](#)

Usability study: parameters



Study type:

Unmoderated usability study



Location:

United States, remote



Participants:

5 participants



Length:

20-30 minutes

Usability study: findings

These were the main findings uncovered by the usability study:

1

Navigation Confusion

Participants struggled to locate key information, such as service times and contact details, indicating a need for clearer navigation and information architecture.

2

Donation Process Difficulty

The online donation process proved confusing and cumbersome, with multiple participants expressing frustration with the multi-step process and unclear instructions.

3

Mobile Responsiveness

Several participants using tablets or smaller screens experienced layout issues and difficulty interacting with certain elements, highlighting the need for improved mobile responsiveness.

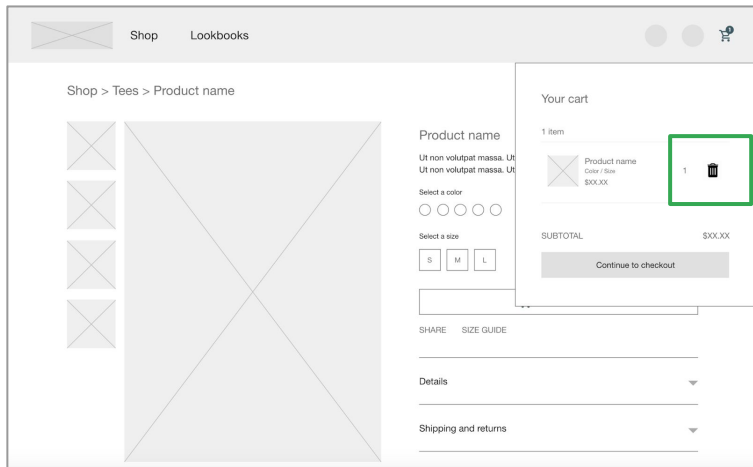
Refining the design

- Mockups
- High-fidelity prototype
- Accessibility

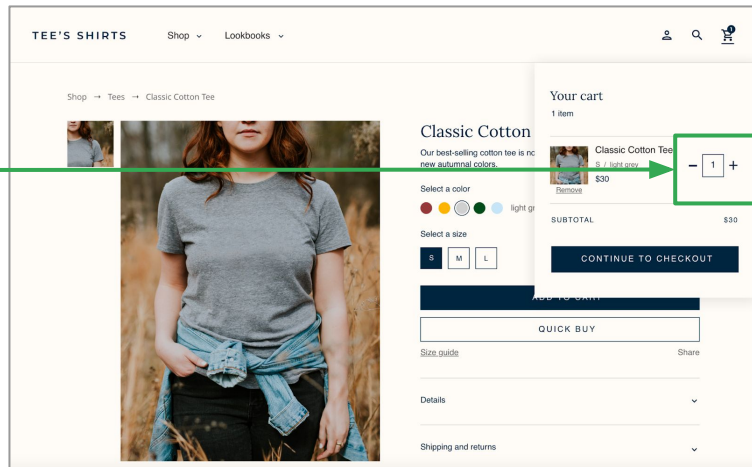
Mockups

Based on the usability study insights, I revised the mockups to improve Eleanor's experience on the church website. A key change was simplifying the online donation process, addressing the confusion and lengthiness she encountered. I focused on making it more intuitive and streamlined.

Before usability study



After usability study



Mockups

To further simplify the donation process for Eleanor, I added a checkbox allowing her to use the same information for her donation and any potential contact information, streamlining the process and reducing redundant data entry.

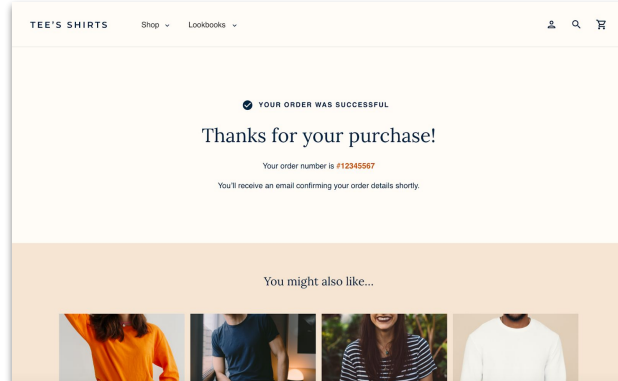
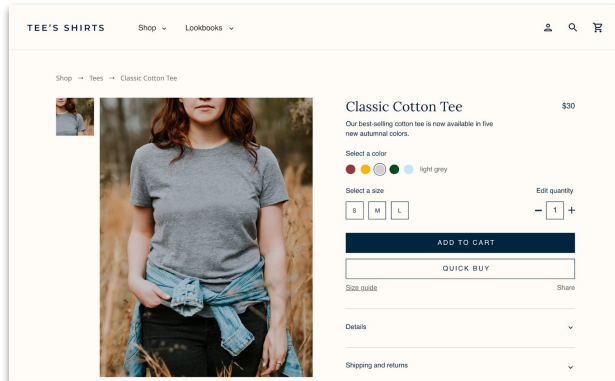
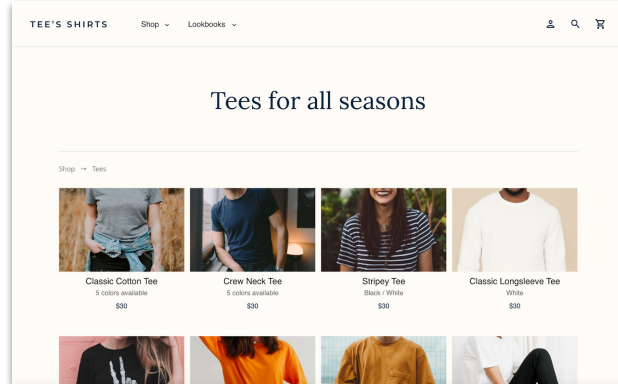
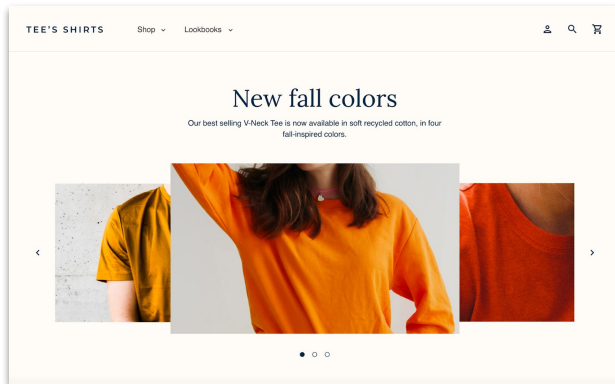
Before usability study

The mockup shows a checkout process with four steps: 1. Address, 2. Shipping, 3. Payment, and 4. Review. The 'Payment' section is active, showing fields for Card number, Expiration date, and CVC. The 'Billing Address' section is highlighted with a green box and contains fields for First name, Second name, Address, City, and State. The 'Order summary' on the right shows 1 item, Subtotal (\$XXX), Shipping (\$XXX), and Order Total (\$XXX). A 'Continue' button is at the bottom right.

After usability study

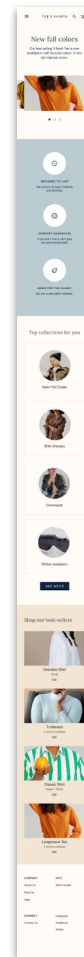
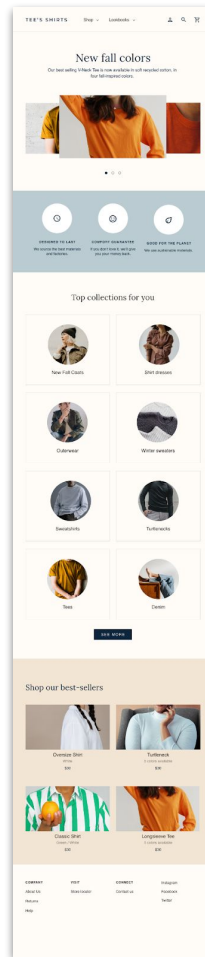
The mockup shows the same checkout process, but with a new 'BILLING ADDRESS' section highlighted by a green box. This section contains two radio button options: 'Same as shipping address' and 'Use a different address'. The 'Payment' section now includes a 'PAYMENT INFORMATION' header and a 'Card number' field. The 'Order summary' on the right shows 1 item, Subtotal (\$30), Shipping (FREE), and Order Total (\$30). A 'CONTINUE' button is at the bottom right.

Mockups: Original screen size



Mockups: Screen size variations

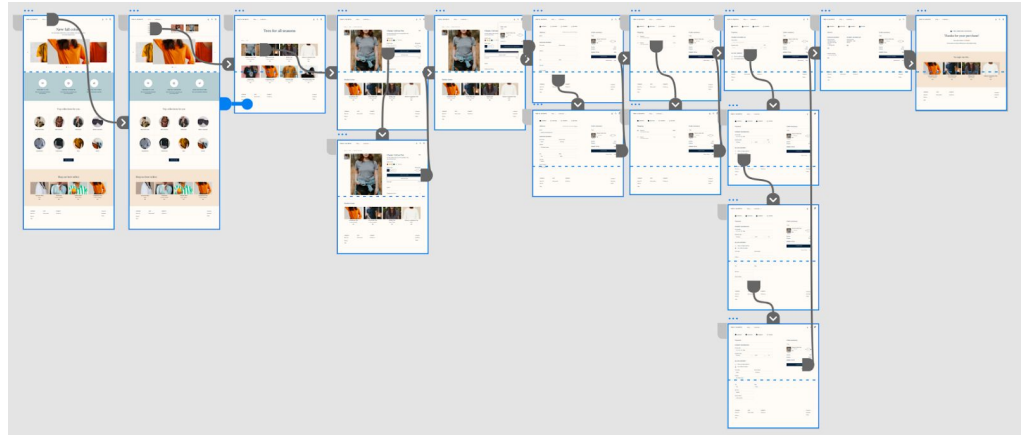
Building on the wireframes, I designed mockups that considered various screen sizes. Recognizing that users access the site from different devices, optimizing the browsing experience for mobile, tablet, and desktop was crucial for a seamless user experience.



High-fidelity prototype

The high-fidelity prototype mirrored the low-fidelity prototype's user flow but incorporated changes from the usability study and team feedback.

[View the high-fidelity prototype.](#)



Accessibility considerations

1

Font Size and Contrast: Ensure sufficient font size and high contrast between text and background. Eleanor, like many older adults, may experience some vision changes, making it difficult to read small or low-contrast text. Allowing users to adjust font size is also beneficial.

2

Keyboard Navigation: The website should be fully navigable using a keyboard alone. Some users may have difficulty using a mouse or trackpad, so keyboard accessibility is essential. This includes clear visual indicators of focus for interactive elements.

3

Screen Reader Compatibility: The website's content and structure should be compatible with screen readers. Screen readers are assistive technologies used by people with visual impairments. This involves using semantic HTML, providing alternative text for images, and ensuring proper heading structure.

Going forward

- Takeaways
- Next steps

Takeaways



Impact:

Improved user experience, increased engagement, enhanced church image.



What I learned:

User-centered design, usability testing, iterative design, and accessibility are essential.

Next steps

1

Conduct follow-up
usability testing on the
new website

2

Identify any additional
areas of need and ideate
on new features

Let's connect!



Thank you for reviewing my work on the church website redesign!

If you'd like to see more or get in touch, my contact information is below:

Email: [AIUXDesign.com](mailto:JM@AIUXDesign.com)
Website: JM@AIUXDesign.com